Shakespeare

Measure for Measure

Before turning to Shakespeare's *Measure for Measure*, it is useful to consider the genres of comedy and tragedy. Shakespeare is one of the most remarkable literary artists because he can produce both on a grand scale, taking each dramatic genre to its maximum potential. The contrast between them helps illuminate *Measure for Measure*, one of his great underrated achievements.

Comedy and tragedy characteristically end differently: comedies end in marriage, tragedies in death. In Greek tragedy, heroes commonly have some fatal flaw, do something wrong, and bring disaster upon their lives. Before their death, they come to recognize their flaw and discover something about the human condition. The consequence of this recognition is that the hero realizes something about the human condition as a whole. Tragedy is a very fatalistic dramatic form.

Comedy characteristically ends in marriage rather than death. Marriage can be understood as symbolic sex, but it is also connected with generation and reproduction. Comedy is therefore more closely connected in its conclusions with life and continuity. This is a juxtaposition between ending in death and ending in life. Tragedy concerns death and finality. I would also suggest that tragedy concerns individuals, whereas comedy concerns types.

In Shakespeare's great tragedies, Hamlet is not simply an example of a prince of Denmark, or of a man who thinks too much and acts too little. He is specifically Hamlet, Prince of Denmark. King Lear is not merely a foolish old man who gave his daughters his kingdom. He is a particular man who did a particular thing. His story is not merely an illustration of a general category of foolish old men. Tragedy individuates: it concerns specific individual people.

Comedy, on the other hand, is primarily about types. Molière's titles provide good examples: *The Miser*, not Joe the miser, but the general type of the miser; *The Misanthrope*, not Bob the misanthrope, but the misanthropic man. Even Molière's *Don Juan* falls into this category. Comparing comic and tragic heroes makes the distinction clearer.

If a young man is excessively attracted to women and sleeps around a great deal, we might say, "He's a real Don Juan." Don Juan is not merely a specific person; he is the type of the promiscuous man. Although Molière may appear to violate the rule, Don Juan represents a kind of person.

Imagine instead that the same young man is intensely jealous of the woman in his life. We would not be so inclined to say, "He's a real Othello," although Othello's tragic flaw is excessive jealousy. Othello is a specific person, and we are less inclined to draw analogies between Othello, Hamlet, or King Lear and people around us. Comic heroes are less grand than the strutting and roaring heroes of tragedy. They are much more like us and become recognizable types. They are kinds of people rather than the grand, sharply individuated figures of tragedy. This applies to Aristophanes' comedies as well.

I would argue that it also applies to Shakespeare's comedies, particularly to what I consider his greatest comedy, *Measure for Measure*. Written in 1604, it belongs to the period of his great tragedies, within a few years of *Macbeth*, *King Lear*, *Hamlet*, and *Othello*. Shakespeare is perhaps the preeminent literary switch-hitter in the Western tradition, capable of producing superior comedies and tragedies in quick succession, without a noticeable disjunction in his view of the world. It is striking that he can move between these two dramatic forms while producing such exceptional work in each.

I would take the argument further: tragedy is intrinsically a non-Christian, pagan art form. Consider the characteristic ending of a Greek tragedy such as *Antigone*. Antigone dies. The tragic hero discovers a terrible flaw and the part they have played in bringing about their own demise. In both Greek and Shakespearean tragedy, the superior hero learns something previously unknown about themselves and about the human condition.

The discovery that human beings have no final recourse, that we all eventually die, and that even superior people cause their own destruction leaves us with a fatalistic outlook. In this reading, tragedy's connection with ancient Greece is no accident. A tragedy cannot be written from the Christian perspective because the death of a Christian is not the end of the story. For a Christian, God's judgment inevitably follows, and this utterly changes the meaning of life. Death therefore cannot have the finality that it possesses in the tragic account of human existence.

My argument is that a true tragedy, in which the hero dies unredeemed, cannot be written from the Christian perspective. Redemption and judgment for individual sins are among Christianity's central ideas. Comedy, by contrast, can be a Christian art form. In the case of *Measure for Measure*, I would argue that it is the Christian dramatic form and that this play is the Christian comedy.

The larger claim—that *Measure for Measure* is the greatest comedy in the Western tradition—is an aesthetic judgment. It is my view, which others need not adopt. Shakespeare is hunting intellectual big game here: he is attempting to recapitulate the entire Bible in the form of a comedy. It is an amazing intellectual achievement and marks an apogee of intellectual aspiration and ambition. The ambition concerns not merely individual biblical episodes but the Christian understanding of history in its entirety.

Even if he does not completely succeed, the ambition to bring the whole Bible, and more importantly the whole Christian view of history, into a single allegorical comic narrative is remarkable. If the argument holds, this is the greatest of Shakespeare's comedies, and his comic achievements belong at least on the same level as his tragic achievements. The attempt to give this entirety the allegorical form of one comedy is itself an extraordinary undertaking, even before its success is assessed.

Tragedy generally receives more philosophical attention. It gets all the good ink spilled over it. We possess Aristotle's discussion of tragedy, but not a corresponding discussion of comedy. Perhaps the history of comedy would have been different if we did. I nevertheless regard *Measure for Measure* as the greatest Christian comedy and one of Shakespeare's greatest achievements.

This does not mean that Shakespeare himself was a Christian. I doubt that very much. To my mind, the author of *King Lear* does not express any great hope of eternal salvation and eternal life. Someone who writes such fine tragedies must have a heavy dose of the pagan in him. Shakespeare seems to me an extraordinary intellectual switch-hitter.

When writing this comedy in 1604, he chose to organize it entirely from the Christian perspective—not because he was a devout Christian like St. Augustine, but because he was intellectually showing off. He wanted to show that he was the ultimate literary artist, capable of writing the best possible play in any genre. In this interpretation, the intellectual ambitions of *Measure for Measure* reflect pagan vanity rather than Christian devotion.

At the end of Plato's *Symposium,* Socrates argues that the same artist should be able to write both tragedy and comedy. Very few artists have lived up to that possibility. The ability to excel at one genre does not ordinarily entail equal mastery of the other. Shakespeare seems determined to do so.

The characters are essential to *Measure for Measure*. First, there are minor figures with no major symbolic importance: Elbow, Pompey, Froth, and Mistress Overdone. These figures belong to the play's comic underworld or its policing; Mistress Overdone keeps a brothel. Throughout the play, at various critical moments, they provide comic relief. They keep the serious symbolic argument from overwhelming the comedy.

Comic relief matters in a comedy that seeks to encapsulate Christianity. Without slapstick elements, the work would lose its comic character and become far too serious. Shakespeare balances these demands by including comic relief that does not form part of the play's essential symbolic structure. The other principal characters, however, can be read symbolically: the whole Christian view of history is present, and each main character carries a Christian association.

The Duke rules Vienna, where the play is set. At the beginning, he leaves for reasons not apparent to the other characters, delegating his authority to Angelo, with Escalus assisting him. At the end, he returns, removes his disguise, and judges those who have acted wickedly. He comes back to judge everyone who has been wicked during the course of the play. This sounds specifically and suspiciously like the end of the world.

The two men he leaves in charge can be understood as personifications of Greek wisdom. Escalus is a wise older man who understands human frailties and flaws. He continually argues for mercy because people cannot always meet the standard of the law. He understands human weakness and the impossibility of creating a perfect political order. His wisdom consists in knowing that human beings are not capable of consistently satisfying the law's demands.

Angelo represents another element of the Greek tradition. His name suggests his disposition: he thinks he can be perfect. He represents Platonic perfectionism. Because he has never felt the temptations he sees in others, he believes himself immune to their sins, superior to them, and capable of standing in for the Duke.

He attempts to do so, but this would-be angel proves incapable of perfection. Lust, a sin associated here with the fall of humanity at the beginning of the Bible, becomes his

downfall. It is a temptation he has never experienced before. The sin he believed himself immune to is precisely the sin that defeats his claim to be a perfect substitute for the absent ruler.

Another relevant character is Lucio. In this reading, his name suggests Lucifer: the devil, the tempter. He frequents the brothel that has recently been pulled down and appears in many comic scenes. Besides being a hellion and a tempter, he is an accomplished blasphemer. He claims to know the Duke well and says that the Duke drinks, chases women, and has many moral vices. Lucio plays the devil's role, representing sin and temptation. His claims about the Duke's private life are not incidental: they form part of his habitual slander and blasphemy.

Isabella is another central figure. She is a novice nun who has not yet taken her final vows, but she is intensely pious and devoted. She prays, fasts, practises mortification of the flesh, and is a virgin. What matters here is not virginity alone, but virginity as a symbol of an uncorrupted self, free from sin or at least resistant to its temptations.

Isabella preserves her chastity throughout the play. I suggest that she represents the Christian Church. Through her, the play examines the relationship between church and state. Her encounters with Angelo, the man who would be perfect, are especially intriguing for understanding how a Christian might view history. Her chastity remains intact while political authority attempts to draw her into corruption.

Claudio, Isabella's brother, has a smaller role but sets the plot in motion. He has been caught in fornication: he has made his betrothed pregnant. Vienna has tolerated considerable sexual licence, but after the Duke's departure Angelo passes judgment on Claudio. In effect, he tells him that he must die for his sins.

This creates the tension of the first act. The Duke has departed, and Angelo and Escalus must determine how to exercise their authority. Angelo seeks both personal perfection and a perfect political order. His position amounts to this: the law will now be enforced without pity or mercy; Vienna will have moral perfection. With the Duke gone and the authority of Vienna in his hands, Angelo resolves to enforce the law absolutely and to create a perfect political order.

Angelo believes himself justified because he thinks he is without sin. The play contains many biblical references. In the account of the woman taken in adultery in the *Gospel of John*, Jesus tells those who would stone her, "He that is without sin among you, let him first cast a stone at her" (John 8:7). Angelo would be at the front of the line, ready to cast the first stone, because he has not absorbed the Christian message. He thinks his own sinlessness gives him the right to judge others.

The title *Measure for Measure* recalls Matthew 7:1–2: "Judge not, that ye be not judged. For with what judgment ye judge, ye shall be judged: and with what measure ye mete, it shall be measured to you again." This is a play about justice, mercy, and the possibility of extending charity to everyone. Human governments are composed of frail, fallible, sinful people who themselves need charity and mercy as well as justice. The measure you give will be the measure you get back.

With the Duke absent, Angelo decides to become something superhuman, dispensing justice in God's stead and enforcing the law perfectly. In Act 1, Scene 2, Lucio learns that

his friend Claudio has been imprisoned and condemned. He then does what appears to be his only altruistic act in the play. Generally unkind and malicious, he decides to help Claudio by visiting the convent where Isabella is preparing to take her vows and persuading her to intercede with Angelo for her brother's life.

What seems kind-hearted is, in this interpretation, the opposite. Lucio sets one saint, or would-be saint, against another: one who understands Christian morality against a Pharisee, a hypocrite, a man who would be perfect. Whichever falls and whichever remains steadfast, the tempter wins. He sets one image of virtue against another, knowing that they cannot both stand. One is genuinely saintly and the other only believes himself saintly. The apparent kindness of helping Claudio conceals the temptation that the encounter creates. The encounter is diabolically contrived.

Isabella goes to Angelo, with Lucio urging her on from the side. Unaccustomed to dealing with politicians, she struggles to know what to say. She holds back because she recognizes some justice in her brother's punishment. She believes fornication is wrong and that Claudio deserves punishment, but she considers death excessive. She pleads for mercy, asking that justice be tempered rather than denying that her brother has done wrong.

Her pleas go unanswered, yet they gradually begin to melt Angelo like an ice cube, from the inside out: his soul melts first. Her request for mercy does not persuade him to abandon the sentence, but it awakens a desire he has never previously known. For the first time, he feels lust. The man who would be perfect begins to become corrupt. As the saying goes, "Power tends to corrupt, and absolute power corrupts absolutely."

The Duke's mysterious departure is a test of Angelo, whom he regards as a man of particularly high moral standing. If Angelo cannot bear the responsibility of political power, no human being can dispense God's justice. The play becomes an elaborate Christian criticism of the attempt to perfect society while ignoring the tragic insight that human beings are essentially flawed and incapable of perfection.

Lucio encourages Isabella to press harder and persuade Angelo to save her brother. The more persuasive her arguments become, the more Angelo melts. When she leaves, he is completely unnerved by his first encounter with lust. He says: "O cunning enemy, that, to catch a saint, / With saints dost bait thy hook!" Satan's snares are carefully laid. Once the play is understood allegorically and symbolically, its elements begin to fall into place. The saintly woman herself becomes the bait by which the would-be saint is caught. This is what makes the psychological encounter so remarkable.

Angelo has sent Isabella away, asking her to return the next day because he cannot speak to her any longer. He is losing his grip. In Act 2, Scene 3, the Duke appears disguised as a friar. He has returned to Vienna as a holy man, without the pomp of a political ruler.

The friar overhears things that the Duke is not supposed to hear. The recurring theme of overhearing people who think they are alone points to God's omnipotence and omniscience. God knows everything, including the secrets people believe they are keeping from the public. The friar overhears secret plans and works to prevent immoral consequences, keeping people on the straight and narrow. He spends a great deal of time listening to what people say when they believe no one with authority can hear

them. Angelo does not know that the friar is the Duke, or that the Duke has returned to discover what kind of man he is.

When Isabella returns, Angelo confronts her directly: he will pardon her brother only if she has sex with him. She must give up her virginity and, in her understanding, jeopardize her salvation by committing a mortal sin, while her brother is allowed to live. The choice, as she sees it, is between her own eternal damnation and her brother's continued earthly life. The irony is that Claudio is being prosecuted for fornication, while the supposedly perfect Angelo proposes sexual blackmail. He is not merely a Pharisee and a hypocrite; he is worse than the man he condemns. The man prosecuting sexual immorality uses the authority of his office to demand a sexual act for himself.

At first Isabella cannot comprehend the proposal. Her chastity and devotion make the idea of exchanging sex for mercy incomprehensible. In her appeals, she speaks some of Shakespeare's greatest poetry on mercy, charity, and justice. She says: "I would to heaven I had your potency, / And you were Isabel! should it then be thus? / No; I would tell what 'twere to be a judge, / And what a prisoner."

Much of her poetry concerns the virtues of mercy and charity alongside justice. The argument is the Golden Rule: if their positions were reversed, she would grant him the clemency he denies her. His demand would corrupt her, himself, and political life even further. The supposedly perfect political order would end up morally worse than the imperfect order it was meant to replace. The attempt to create a perfect political order or a perfect individual is bound to produce a worse moral condition. The futility of Platonic perfectionism, and the discovery that the supposedly perfect man is a "whited sepulchre," a hypocrite worse than those he judges, are built into this powerful, ironic encounter.

Angelo grows progressively more evil. When Isabella vehemently refuses him, he threatens to torture her brother to death. She will not surrender the possibility of eternal life, whatever he does to Claudio. Her brother deserves punishment because he has sinned; for her to surrender salvation would be a greater loss than for him to surrender the brief period of earthly life allotted to human beings.

The moral tension reaches an impasse. Angelo seems likely to prevail, but the friar overhears a conversation between Isabella and Claudio in prison. She tells Claudio that he must die because Angelo has propositioned her and she has refused. Initially, Claudio is brave and understands that she cannot lose her soul for him. Soon, however, he begs her to sleep with Angelo and save his life.

Isabella's furious response makes Lady Macbeth seem gentle. She lashes out at him with an absolute fury that one would not expect from a novice nun. Her reaction is that of a virago, fierce enough to make the comparison with Lady Macbeth seem inadequate. Claudio has not only sinned in the flesh; he now seeks to cause his sister's damnation. She condemns his weakness and refuses.

The friar intervenes, assuring Isabella that he will take care of matters. He has also spoken to Juliet, the woman Claudio has made pregnant, asking whether she repents her sins or merely their consequences. She says that she repents sincerely and from the heart. She repents the sins themselves, not simply the trouble that has followed them. The friar's concern is the sincerity of her inward repentance. He tells Claudio to prepare

for death: he has sinned and must not expect clemency. He claims to know Angelo's heart and tells Claudio that Angelo was only testing Isabella and was pleased to find her chaste and virtuous. To Isabella, however, he offers a way in which they can make the situation work without her yielding to Angelo.

The friar then conspires with Isabella to trick Angelo. The Duke knows that, before his elevation to office, Angelo was betrothed and broke off the engagement for an insufficient reason. The woman, Mariana, still loves him despite his abominable treatment of her. This is not intended as a realistic portrayal of sexual desire. The Duke knows where to find her and arranges the substitution of one woman for another in Angelo's bed. The Duke's knowledge of this secret betrothal is another sign of the omniscience attributed to him. Omniscience is particularly useful if the character is understood as Yahweh.

Shakespearean comedy repeatedly concerns the mistaking of appearance for reality. Angelo believes that his secret meeting will be with Isabella and that he will get what he wants. The Duke has the arrangement in hand: the meeting will take place in darkness and silence, so that Mariana's voice does not betray her identity. The darkness conceals the woman's appearance, and the silence conceals her voice. These themes of light and darkness, silence and the word, point toward the biblical symbolism.

Angelo believes he has consummated his sin. He has sinned in his heart and intention. From the Christian perspective adopted here, the failure to commit the precise act he intended does not alter that intention. He is a sinner because he intended to sin, and he will be judged on the basis of that intention. When they separate after the meeting, he believes he has accomplished what he set out to do. In reality, he has slept with the woman to whom he was betrothed.

The bed trick does not secure Claudio's release. One sin leads to another: there is no sin in the singular. Angelo becomes an utterly Machiavellian individual. If Claudio is freed and learns that his life was purchased at the cost of his sister's salvation, he may seek revenge in this world. Claudio might believe that both he and his sister have been damned as a consequence of the bargain. Angelo does not want to leave alive a man who could discover what he has done. Angelo therefore sends orders to the prison for Claudio's immediate execution. He double-crosses the nun he believes he has exploited. Had Isabella slept with him, her brother would have died anyway.

Her religious idealism proves practically sound. Refusing to yield is the way to preserve her hope of salvation and, as events unfold, her brother's life. The friar tells the provost not to carry out Claudio's execution. There will be a second substitution: Claudio's head stays on his shoulders, while the head of another prisoner, who has died of a fever, is sent to Angelo. The head is put into a bag and delivered in place of Claudio's. Angelo will not know the difference. The Duke's plan therefore substitutes both a woman in the bed and a head at the prison.

There is now a double substitution. Angelo believes that he has murdered Claudio and deflowered Isabella. He thinks he has entirely lost his soul. He must now answer for his actions because he and Escalus unexpectedly receive letters announcing the Duke's return.

I suggest that these writings, which the Duke sends or promises throughout the play, represent the Bible. They announce that he will return and judge everyone correctly, seeing into souls and intentions. Fallible human justice, by contrast, concerns itself with actions and cannot fully understand intentions. Angelo and Escalus are perplexed by the news of the Duke's return.

Escalus has done no wrong. He has been a kind and merciful judge because he understands the wisdom of tragedy: people are intrinsically imperfect, and the best one can do is ameliorate their flaws, never eliminate them. Angelo, by trying to perfect both himself and Vienna, has committed the sin of pride. His hubris prevents his sanctification. Trying to be perfect has not made him holy; it has opened the path to a succession of sins. Once he takes the first step toward sin, sin follows sin. This is the fall of a potentially superior man.

Angelo has many qualities of a tragic hero, but his ending is comic. He receives life rather than death. The potentially tragic fall does not therefore culminate in the finality characteristic of tragedy. When the Duke returns, Isabella mistakenly believes Claudio has been killed. She is heartbroken. Although she accepts that her brother deserves punishment, she had hoped for mercy and charity alongside justice. Angelo's attempt to exploit her makes the situation more painful. She meets the returning Duke at the city gates.

Isabella and Mariana come as supplicants demanding justice against Angelo. Biblical imagery contrasts holy and profane cities, Jerusalem and Babylon. Vienna has been a corrupt city, a city of man rather than a city of God, a kind of Babylon. With the Duke's second coming, this Babylon is transformed: the world moves from the profane to the sacred.

The Duke and the friar are revealed as the same person. In this interpretation, the concluding scene reprises the *Book of Revelation*: God returns to judge humanity, and everyone receives both justice and mercy.

The gates open. Angelo and Escalus meet the Duke and return the symbols of authority. The Duke invites those who believe they have been mistreated to bring their complaints directly to him. Mariana has slept with Angelo, but he believes he has slept with Isabella. Isabella accuses him of hypocrisy, judicial murder, and the violation of a virgin. She presents him as a hypocrite, a murderer exercising judicial power, and an evil man in every respect. The Duke, now back in the city, plays it very cool.

Initially he acts like a temporal rather than a spiritual ruler, a man rather than God, professing disbelief because Angelo has an excellent reputation. Reputation is important in human judgments of character and testimony. A human judge might be swayed by Angelo's apparently faultless record, but this ending offers a divine judge who is not deceived by reputation. Perfect justice is combined with mercy: measure is met with measure.

The Duke leaves Angelo and Escalus to investigate who has prompted these supposedly wicked women to lie about the supposedly virtuous Angelo. Their task is to discover who has persuaded these women to make their accusations. There is layer upon layer of irony in allowing the accused man to take charge of the investigation. Angelo is nervous

because he is close to exposure. He hopes to escape by finding the man who put the women up to it: the friar.

Lucio tells the Duke that he knows the friar and that the friar is wicked, unlike the holy man Vienna should expect. Earlier he told the friar that he knew the Duke, who was a woman-chaser, drinker, and carouser. Symbolically, he tells God to his face that he knows God and that God is immoral. He makes these claims before the very face of the person he is slandering. This is the sin of blasphemy, and in committing it he prepares his own condemnation.

After the Duke leaves, the friar appears. Lucio gives false testimony against this good friar, who has urged repentance, extended mercy, and tried to keep people from sin. He rails against him and finally pulls off his hood. Beneath it is the Duke himself. Lucio realizes that he has slandered the Duke to the friar and the friar to the Duke. He has been caught, and there is no way to evade what he has said. The same person has heard both sets of accusations. There is no escape. Angelo also realizes that he has been exposed.

Mariana explains the bed trick. Angelo discovers that, although he has committed many sins, he has not committed the act he thought he had committed with Isabella. The Duke orders him to marry Mariana and then condemns him to death. The man who would be perfect has hypocritically used his claimed morality to engage in worse conduct than that which he condemns. Mariana is to inherit his property, so that he can no longer mistreat her as he has for years.

Angelo undergoes a remarkable change of heart. He acknowledges that he deserves death and asks only to be killed immediately. He finally recognizes what he is: he thought he could be perfect and has failed. All he merits now is death. His request amounts to this: he accepts the sentence, admits the failure of his claim to perfection, and asks that death come without delay.

Mariana, extraordinarily kind and good-natured, begs the Duke to spare her husband despite his faults and wickedness. She loves him and asks for mercy. When the Duke is not moved, she turns to Isabella: “Lend me your knees.” She asks her to kneel and pray for mercy and clemency. Her appeal is striking because Isabella has every personal reason to want Angelo condemned.

Isabella still believes this man has killed her brother. He tried to coerce her into sex, which she believed would cost her soul. She is now in the position she described to Angelo in Act 2: if she were the judge and he the supplicant, she would extend mercy. This is the Golden Rule of the Gospels.

At the turning point, she kneels and asks forgiveness for Angelo. She thinks that, at least in part, his earlier severity came from a sincere belief that he was doing right. Some intention remains capable of redemption. Isabella does not deny his wrongdoing, but recognizes that his earlier wish to enforce the law need not have been wholly insincere. Although he meant to do wrong and she believes he wronged her brother, she asks the Duke to spare him. Mercy is ultimately granted.

Isabella has been tested. Her willingness to extend mercy to someone who denied it to her, exploited her, and apparently killed her brother reveals her genuinely Christian

ethical motivation. She is the uncorrupted Christian and a personification of the Church. In Christian theology, the Church intercedes with God for sinful human beings.

If Angelo represents the state, their conflict is the enduring conflict of church and state, in which politics attempts to corrupt religion. Yet at the end of the world, religion and the Church are there to intercede for corrupt, immoral human beings and make their salvation possible. The very religion that politics has attempted to corrupt becomes the means of intercession for sinful political humanity.

Angelo confesses his sins, recognizes that he deserves death, and receives the benefit of intercessory prayer. The Duke commutes his sentence. Angelo is to remain married to Mariana and transgress no more. He now understands who he is and what he is. That recognition will be enough; the penalty is commuted rather than carried out. He might even consider changing his name; it no longer suits him very well.

After Isabella has prayed for the man she believes killed her brother, Claudio appears alive. The substitution of the head, like the substitution in the bed, has succeeded. Her brother enters, and the reunion is joyful. Isabella's prayer has been offered without knowing that the injury she is prepared to forgive has been prevented. Juliet has repented, and Claudio receives mercy. Divine justice and divine mercy are not completely distinguishable. Although Angelo's judgment recognized Claudio's offence, the Duke spares him, extending justice and mercy together.

Claudio is to marry Juliet, and Angelo has married Mariana. The Duke asks Isabella to marry him. The ending offers the prospect of their marriage. I read this as an echo of the ending of the *Book of Revelation*: God marrying his Church, described in Revelation as the bride of Christ. These images and metaphors do not enter the play accidentally.

The allegory is so detailed that it includes even the devil. Lucio unmasks the Duke, who begins to dispense justice and mercy, and the ending becomes a scene of multiple marriages. Comedy characteristically ends in marriage. Marriage is the inverse of the tragic hero's death. Tragedy individuates: Othello becomes Othello, Hamlet becomes Hamlet, because each is who he is.

Marriage does the opposite: it reintegrates people into society. Fairy tales end, "And they lived happily ever after." Comedy contains a longing for eternal life, opposing tragedy's movement toward death. What could better suit a Christian interpretation of history than a conclusion in which everyone is rightly judged and acknowledged as sinful, yet reintegrated into society through God's mercy, which overlaps with his justice? The ending returns sinful individuals to communal life rather than leaving them isolated in death. This is an absolutely amazing theological tour de force.

The devil does not escape. While the marriages, judgments, and acts of mercy take place, Lucio tries to slip offstage into the shadows. A director needs an actor who can slink convincingly, because shadow and light matter in a production of this play. But the Duke knows everything. In this allegory he is Yahweh, omniscient, so Lucio cannot sneak away.

The Duke calls him back to speak. He cannot help but come forward and meet his maker, literally speaking, by dealing with the Duke. The Duke confronts him with his claims that the Duke is a drunkard, a woman-chaser, a carouser, and an evil man. The

Duke asks whether he remembers making such claims and confronts him with the words he has heard. Lucio tries to get out of the situation by saying he did not really mean it.

The Duke sentences him to whipping and hanging, but also to marriage. Lucio has made a prostitute pregnant and must marry her before the other penalties are carried out. Before the whipping and hanging, he must be married so that the woman and her child are provided for. His visits to the brothel have produced a child whose existence he cannot simply ignore.

I suggest that this is Lucio the devil being married to the Whore of Babylon. Even he receives a degree of mercy: the whipping and hanging are remitted. All he has to do is make an honest woman of her through marriage and make their child legitimate. The devil himself is thus caught up in the comic conclusion's combination of judgment and mercy. I would venture the guess that the child is symbolically named Sin. This is perhaps the greatest achievement of comic art.

Many further symbolic elements could be identified, including at least a hundred direct references to the *New Testament*. These biblical references are not a handful of isolated allusions. The play is saturated with Christian mythology and symbolism. Without its Christian iconography, it makes no sense. Read as a realistic representation of human sexual desire, it is laughably bad and might seem Shakespeare's worst play. Read through its Christian iconography, it is his greatest comedy and arguably the greatest comedy ever written.

Mark 4:24 provides the biblical resonance of the final scene: "With what measure ye mete, it shall be measured to you: and unto you that hear shall more be given." The "more" is God's mercy, which follows his judgment at the end of the play.

In this reading, *Measure for Measure* is a Trinitarian Christian play. God the Father, Yahweh, departs and sets the world in motion, then returns to judge. God also returns as a holy man, the friar who tells people to repent their sins: this is Jesus. At the end, when divine justice and divine mercy prove inseparable, there is the return of the Spirit. The spirit of the law is that mercy and justice cannot be distinguished.